

Chrome delivers on promise

Google's Chrome web browser is now into version 7. As promised, Google sends out a new version of Chrome every six weeks

Market watch

This year has seen an interesting emergence of domestic brands, and in a big way. We saw the launch of no less than five new brands, and the year isn't even over yet. Most of these brands are cautious, initially launching entry-level phones. This is obviously the way to go, in a market that is dominated by big names. And most people like to play the volumes game, for that is what builds revenue. Building and (successfully) marketing a handset worth ₹30,000, is not an easy task, and requires lots of initial investments and expertise.

Over the year, we've seen some of these minnows gradually move up the price ladder, obviously buoyed by their success in the lower rungs. This is heartening from our perspective, as more competition can only be good for us consumers. In fact, breaking into a market already replete with brands is no easy task, and kudos to minnows such as Spice, Intex, Micromax, Lava, Karbonn, Maxx, Rage, Lemon, Videocon and others who we haven't mentioned here. They have forced some bigger brands to drop prices of mid-range products and introduce entry-level phones!

Android has emerged as a platform to be reckoned with. We've seen a number of vendors jump on to the Android platform, and we've seen a number of flagship devices on this platform this year, from the likes of Motorola, HTC and Samsung. We've also seen a few cheaper Android phones, close to the ₹10,000 mark. This is also welcome, since initially we perceived this to be an expensive platform.

Windows Phone 7 (WP7) has just launched, and as expected, there have been a slew of new releases from LG, HTC, Samsung and even Dell. WP 7 challenges Android, for it is a complete redesign, and nothing like its predecessor – it's modern, highly usable and customisable and the lack of native capacitive touch support, which was a serious chink in Microsoft's armour has been overcome.

This year also sees the welcome return of the teetering giant Motorola. Once perceived to be on the brink of extinction, they're back, and quite miraculously, on account of a single phone – the Motorola Droid (or Motorola Milestone), whose sales, single-handedly restored their treasury reserves. As a salute to Android that powered the Droid, they now have an entire range of phones, on the platform.

Important results from our survey

- 1) The biggest shift in Nokia's dominance of power came in the awareness index, where Motorola and Samsung caught up to Nokia, with identical scores and other brands like LG, Apple, Blackberry and Sony Ericsson trailing slightly.
- 2) Last year, Nokia had a 2.5x lead over its nearest competitor in the awareness arena. This dominion is history. People are more aware of the other options available. The awareness level for Motorola climbed 8 times, and HTC 6 times. So more of our readers are aware that there are other viable brands.
- 3) Lots of people trust Apple, just a fraction less than those who trust Nokia. People also trust Samsung, Sony Ericsson and Blackberry, but less than the first two. A lot of people trust Samsung over LG, although both are Korean brands.
- 4) Blackberry was the major climber in terms of satisfaction from last year. It climbed six points, meaning fewer BlackBerry owners have anything to complain about.

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